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Culture (OWC): [Tallensi \(FE11\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1934-1937

Coverage Date: 1934-1938

Place Coverage: Tongo Village, Ghana

Section Title(S): III. SOCIAL SPHERE OF THE 'TALE CHILD

The structure of this relationship makes it possible for children to acquiesce immediately in the commands and teachings of their parents or parent-substitutes. Children are, as a rule, very obedient. If they refuse to carry out an order there is usually some very valid reason—acknowledged as such by both parents and children—such as that it is some one else's turn. But the parent-child relationship is educationally fundamental in another sense—it is the paradigm of all moral relationships.

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It is worth noting, by contrast, that the relationship between grandparent and grandchild is the reverse of that between parent and child. In this case equality, comatibility and partisanship, as if in league against the generation between them, are emphasized, more particularly by the joking relationship—mutual ragging among the Tallensi—permitted between grandparent and grandchild.

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The social space. How these relationships function in the educational development of a Tale child is determined by its social space.¹ An individual's social space is a product of that segment of the social structure and that segment of the habitat with which he or she is in effective contact. To put it in another way, the social space is the society in its ecological setting seen from the individual's point of view. The individual creates his social space but is himself in turn formed by it. On the one hand, his range of experiences and behaviour are controlled by his social space, and on the other, everything he learns causes it to expand and become more differentiated. In the lifetime of the individual it changes *pari passu* with his psycho-physical and social development.

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¹ This term is employed here for want of an apter one. It has been used in a different sense by Simmel and others.

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